Within days of the Berlin Wall's construction, citizens from across the United States went against the mainstream inclinations to treat the Wall as isolated spectacle and began evoking the Berlin boundary as a metaphor for racial barriers in America in more grassroots venues and platforms. Activists, artists, and politicians used differing forms of cultural communication to highlight the ongoing struggle for equality through the rhetoric of America's Berlin. The barriers they contested included the elusive but violently policed color line; they also referred to existing architectures of segregation in cities (including walls, fences, and pernicious "common sense" boundaries) that divided redlined housing districts from other residential areas or prohibited mobility for black citizens more ostensibly. Public speeches in late 1961 from prominent black Americans, such as State Department official Carl Rowan, NAACP president Roy Wilkins, and Fort Valley State College president Cornelius V. Troup, explored dimensions of U.S. racial segregation by relating civil rights struggles to the construction of the Berlin Wall.[17]